cameraperson enthusiastically. ‘We can give a human touch to the show.’ Unfortunately, the moment I broached the idea of filming the birthday party, both Dr Singh and wife shook their heads sternly in unison. ‘The birthday is a private affair, no cameras please!’ I tried to reason that as an aspiring MP, the lines between the private and the public were now blurred, but to no avail. The Singhs were determined to zealously guard their family life.

Dr Singh lost that South Delhi election to the BJP’s Vijay Kumar Malhotra by a little over 29,000 votes. He never contested a Lok Sabha election again. And yet, by a remarkable quirk of fate, this intensely private, soft-spoken Sardar became prime minister five years later. A nation-building intellectual of the 1960s, Manmohan Singh was part of a generation that had been the frontiersmen of ‘Nehruvian’ modernity. Indira Gandhi had sought his counsel as well, and he was acknowledged as a highly competent scholar-bureaucrat. Sonia Gandhi had chosen him ahead of all other contenders because she trusted him and, equally importantly, respected him as a man of high personal integrity. Initially, the decision to anoint Dr Singh as prime minister appeared to catch everyone by surprise, except the renowned Oxford scholar and guru of psephology, Sir David Butler. Sir David had known Dr Singh since his Oxford days, and was in India to observe the elections. ‘You know, he will make an ideal prime minister in a coalition government in India, the kind of man who will offend no one but will quietly get the job done,’ was his sharp analysis.

In the first five years of the UPA government, it appeared that Sir David’s assessment was near perfect. The ‘accidental politician’, as Dr Singh often described himself, proved to be an artful one too, cleverly negotiating the minefield of a government dependent on several allies. I sometimes met him in those early years in 7, Race Course Road, courtesy his proactive media adviser, Dr Sanjaya Baru. Dr Singh was unfailingly warm and polite. Power, it seemed, had not changed him a bit. Even the family, mercifully for an Indian politician, stayed away from the lure of office, exuding a no-nonsense feet-firmly-on-the-ground air.

When the Indo-US nuclear deal threatened to torpedo his government, with the left warning of a pull out, I was tipped off by a Congress source